

CITIZEN ENGAGEMENT STRATEGY

WITH A FOCUS ON OUTPUT-BASED BUDGETING
AND PROJECT IMPLEMENTATION MANAGEMENT
2025-2028



REPUBLIC OF ZAMBIA
NDOLA CITY COUNCIL

ABSTRACT

The Ndola Citizen Engagement Strategy (2025-2028) establishes a comprehensive framework for the Ndola City Council to institutionalize a systematic, transparent, and meaningful dialogue with its citizens. Anchored in Zambia's legal and policy framework for decentralized governance, this strategy aims to foster a culture of transparency, accountability, and active citizen participation across all cycles of urban governance, with a specific focus on Output-Based Budgeting and project implementation management.

The strategy outlines a multi-faceted approach to engagement, leveraging existing structures like Ward Development Committees (WDCs) while introducing enhanced methods for communication, monitoring, and feedback. It includes a detailed implementation plan aligned with the budget cycle, a supporting communication strategy, a dedicated budget, and a robust monitoring and evaluation framework to ensure the strategy's objectives of improved inclusivity, strengthened accountability, and enhanced governmental responsiveness are effectively met.

Signed



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Introduction

Ndola City Council is the third-largest city; once an economic nerve center of the Copperbelt Province, faces unique and complex urban governance challenges. With a population exceeding 455,194 (2022 Census) spread across 33 wards, the city is a mosaic of formal and informal settlements, industrial zones, and commercial centers. This diversity necessitates a governance model that is not only responsive but also proactively inclusive.

Ndola City Council recognizes that effective service delivery and sustainable development are contingent upon understanding and addressing the multifaceted needs of its citizens. This Citizen Engagement Strategy (CES) is thus designed to institutionalize a systematic, transparent, and meaningful dialogue between the Council and the people it serves, particularly within the critical processes of Output-Based Budgeting and project implementation management.

1.1 Background

This Citizen Engagement Strategy is anchored in a robust legal and policy framework, including:

- **The Constitution of Zambia (Amendment) [Act No. 2 of 2016]:** provides for a democratic governance and decentralized governance of the country of Zambia.
- **The Local Government Act No. 2 of 2019:** Provides for an integrated and democratic local governance system that promotes participation in decision making by the people at the local level in driving the development agenda in their communities.
- **The National Planning and Budgeting Act No. 1 of 2020:** Provides for a national and local government planning and budgeting process that strengthens accountability, oversight and participatory mechanisms through promotion of participation of state and non-state actors in planning and budgeting to enhance budgeting credibility.
- **Decentralization policy:** Promotes for a citizen driven local governance as a key pillar for socio – economic transformation agenda; a fully decentralized and democratically elected system for sustainable development .

1.2 Current C.E. Efforts by Ndola City Council

The Council has a history of engagement, primarily through:

- **Ward Development Committees (WDCs):** provided for under the Local Government Act, WDCs form a primary structure for community consultation at local level. These are lower-level governance structures established at each ward to support a bottom-up approach in community development affairs.
- **Council meetings:** a meeting of democratically elected ward representatives known as councilors (sometimes open to the public) to make decision on development matters within the district.
- **District Development Coordinating Committee (DDCC):** provided for under the National Planning and Budgeting Act to enhance coordination of different stakeholders at district level such as FBOs, CSOs, NGOs, government entities, , parastatals and private entities.
- **Annual Budget stakeholder consultative meetings:** these are **town hall** meetings held during the budget formulation cycle as a platform to inform the public on the running budget performance and obtain input on the budget proposal for the following year.
- **Ad-hoc Interactions:** through public awareness and sensitization campaigns accompanied with media briefings, publicity drives in open public places, indoors, at media houses.

The advantages of Citizen engagement efforts include:

- Increases understanding, support, and ownership of projects
- Improves projects design and relevance
- Enhances transparency and accountability
- Improves the Environmental and Social sustainability of projects

The Citizen Engagement Strategy will contribute to the execution of these of the above efforts through inclusive stakeholder mapping efforts for inclusive stakeholder participation in development affairs of the district. These efforts will contribute to:

- Deliberate expansion of target groups for more inclusive participation in CE activities such as people living with disabilities, women, community and traditional leaders etc.
- More information will be shared with the citizens on updates and decisions over the budget and project cycle processes.

Vision, Aim and Objectives

Vision

To provide a structural framework for the council to deepen citizen engagement in the governance in order to improve decision making and foster collaboration between the council and its people by 2028.

- During the three (3) year duration of CES, each year will contain an annual implementation plan. Feedback from each year will be incorporated in the following year action plan and a full revision will be submitted at the beginning of the 3rd year of the CES implementation period.

Aim

To institutionalize a culture of transparency, accountability, and active citizen participation in all cycles of urban governance, from planning and budgeting to implementation, monitoring, and evaluation

Objectives [

- **Improved accessibility and inclusivity:** through ensuring all citizens regardless of local locations, social status, or digital literacy can easily access information and participate in consultation and engage with public decision-making process.
- **Strengthen transparency and accountability:** providing timely, accurate and open information about government policies, budgets, and service delivery to build trust and enable citizens to hold institutions accountable
- **Enhance responsiveness and feedback mechanisms:** develop an efficient systems for collecting , analysing and acting on citizen feedback to ensure that public services and policies reflect community needs and concerns. Enable more inclusion of citizens to participate in budget and project decision-making and prioritization.

Approaches and Methods of Engagement

The Ndola City Council team will use the below stated initiatives for inclusive engagement taking into consideration that citizens are drawn from diverse background. Consideration will be taken about how citizens will engage with civic leaders as well, to ensure that the process is not one sided. The citizen engagement process is on-going, hence the Councils intention to use different avenues and mechanisms to communicate with various stakeholders. Engagement methods will therefore include:

A. Citizen Participation in key Decision-Making and keeping citizens informed through the budget cycle:

- The presentation for the budget hearings will be presented ahead of time to stakeholders to obtain feedback including allocations to different programs/sub programs, key outputs, and selected projects;

- The Citizen Engagement will be emphasized in project selection and prioritization in order to provide a good avenue for informed consultation with WDCs;

B. Citizen Monitoring of Budget and Project Implementation

- CE in project implementation will be fostered through information sharing using various platforms such as radio, TV, Council website where citizens will have access to documents such as the budget, council minutes and other information required by citizens to make informed decisions.
- Improve reporting to citizens on the outputs of the budget implementation. This will be achieved using the following examples:
 - Use technology for real-time reporting on project progress;
 - Publish regular updates and reports;
 - Create accessible channels for concerns or feedback.
- Selected stakeholders will form part of the team as the council conducts monitoring visits.

Implementation Plan

The Ndola City Council will employ a variety of options to foster meaningful citizen engagement with the various multi-sectoral and multilevel stakeholders in the district. Implementation plan of the CES will assess the current status of citizen engagement in the budget process and other relevant subject matters:

A SWOT analysis of the current status of Citizen Engagement will enable the institution to devise better strategies for maximum results as shown below.

Strength ○ Availability of WDC structures to bridge the gap between the local authority and the community ○ Skilled human resource with capacity to engage the public ○ Social media connectivity	Weaknesses ○ Mandatory use of official language when communicating with stakeholders ○ Lack of community centres in communities to congregate large groups of community members ○ Absence of institutional grievance redress mechanism
Opportunities ○ Large district population ○ Availability of laws that mandate citizen engagement ○ Relatively youthful population with high drive to achieve developmental aspirations.	Threats ○ Insufficient funding to undertake inclusive citizen engagement meetings effectively ○ Political influence to participants ○ Cultural values that hinder women and young, including people with disabilities to express themselves in public

From the above analysis, the Ndola Council will employ the CE plan as indicated below:

Table 1: Proposed Stakeholder Engagement Plan Summary

BUDGET STAGE	KEY FEATURES/ACTIVITIES	STAKEHOLDER CATEGORY INVOLVED	TIMELINE
1. Budget Preparation	i. Communicating to communities about proposed dates for consultation	Nil	1 st quarter
	ii. Provide feedback to WDCs on the approved list of submitted projects for of the previous year and the status of the ongoing projects and feedback on completed projects for the past 2 years.	WDC, Ward councillors, NGOs, CSOs, FBO, NGOS, CWACS, EXTENSION OFFICERS, ZAPD, WOMEN GROUPS	2 nd quarter

	iii.	Provide WDCs with a list of proposed projects for consideration in this budget cycle.	WDC, WARD CLLRs, NGO, CSO, FBO, NGOS, CWACS, EXTENSION OFFICERS	
	iv.	Using the project lists provided, communities may accept or reject project proposals and make their own proposals for development projects and activities for their Wards to be included in the budget based on their priorities	WDCs, NGO, CSO, FBO, NGOS, CWACS, EXTENSION OFFICERS, BUSINESS COMMUNITY, DISTRICT CHAMBER OF COMMERCE, MARKETEERS, CIVIC LEADERS, HEADS OF GOVERNMENT DEPARTS, COPPERATIVES, YOUTH GROUPS, WOMEN GROUPS, DIABILITY GROUPS, FARMERS ASSOCIATION, BANKERS, MEDIA HOUSES,	3 rd quarter
	v.	Consolidate a summarized stakeholder report from all Wards		
	vi.	Conduct budget hearings & Town Hall meetings.		
	vii.	The Town Clerk/Council Secretary shall present the reports to the full council.	CIVIC LEADERS & CIVIL SOCIETY	4 th Quarter
	iii.	Feedback meetings to WDCs on what projects and activities have been included in the budget	WDC, WARD CLLRs, NGO, CSO, FBO, NGOS, CWACS, EXTENSION OFFICERS	
2. Budget Approval	i.	Review the proposed budget and assess whether input from community, especially vulnerable groups i.e. women, PWDs and children has been incorporated.	WDC, WARD CLLRs, NGO, CSO, FBO, NGOS, CWACS, EXTENSION OFFICERS	
	ii.	Feedback to WDCs and other stakeholders of the final approved budget	WDC, WARD CLLRs, NGO, CSO, FBO, NGOS, CWACS, EXTENSION OFFICERS	
3. Budget execution and monitoring (for transparency in budget implementation)	i.	Track the effective utilisation of funds in line with planned activities.	WDC, NGO, CSO , FBO, NGOS, CWACS , EXTENSION OFFICERS, CIVIC LEADERS, BUSINESS COMMUNITY	
	ii.	Report back on a regular basis to WDCs on implementation of activities and projects	WDC, NGO, CSO, FBO, NGOS, CWAC , EXTENSION OFFICERS, CIVIC LEADERS, BUSINESS COMMUNITY	
4. Budget evaluation and Review	i.	Evaluation of the impact of allocated funds with focus on agreed upon programmes with a bias towards gender, persons with disabilities, child-related and climate change outcomes.	WDC, NGO, CSO, FBO, NGOS, CWACS , EXTENSION OFFICERS, CIVIC LEADERS, BUSINESS COMMUNITY, HEAD OF DEPARTMENTS	

Communication Plan

The communication plan will include the following as shown in table below:

Table 2: Proposed Communication Plan Summary

DELIVERABLE/ ACTIVITY	TARGET STAKEHOLDERS	FREQUENCY	PROPOSED TIMELINE/ DATE	RESPONSIBILITY	COMMUNICATION METHOD	COMMENTS
Budget Consultation Meetings	Citizens, WDCs, Traditional Leaders, CSOs	Annually (before budget formulation)	March (with notices sent 7 days prior)	Council Secretary, All Directors	Public Meetings, Radio Announcements, Notice Boards	Capture citizen priorities for inclusion in budget. Notices to

						be sent 7 days before activity
Dissemination of Draft Budget	WDCs, Community Leaders, CSOs, Media	Annually	April (with notices sent 7 days prior)	Director Planning, Council Secretary	Physical Meetings, Digital Platforms (website, social media)	Ensure transparency and inclusivity before budget approval
Feedback Meetings on Approved Budget	Citizens, WDCs, Traditional Leaders	Annually (after budget approval)	May (with notices sent 7 days prior)	Council Secretary, WDCs	Public Meetings, Community Radio, Notice Boards	Provide feedback on what projects were included/excluded
Project Launch Announcements	Citizens, Community Groups, Media	As needed (per project)	Continuous (with notices sent 7 days prior)	Project Officers, Council Secretary	Radio Shows, Notice Boards, social media	Inform communities about project commencement and expectations
Monitoring & Progress Updates	Citizens, WDCs, CWACs, CSOs	Quarterly	March, June, September, December (with notices 7 days prior for forums)	All Directors, CS, PLGO, Traditional Leadership, PRO, and NAISE	Reports, Community Forums, Radio Programs	Promote accountability and transparency in implementation
Grievance Redress Mechanism (GRM) Awareness	All citizens, especially vulnerable groups (women, PWDs, youth)	Continuous	Ongoing	Council Secretary, WDCs, Communication Unit	Suggestion Boxes, Hotlines, Public Announcements	Raise awareness about complaint channels and ensure usage
Capacity Building Workshops	WDCs, CWACs, CSOs, Traditional Leaders	Bi-annually	May, October (with notices sent 7 days prior)	Director planning, CSOs, PLGO	Workshops, Digital Platforms	Strengthen stakeholder participation and knowledge
Budget Consultation Meetings	Citizens, WDCs, Traditional Leaders, CSOs	Annually (before budget formulation)	March (with notices sent 7 days prior)	Council Secretary, All Directors	Public Meetings, Radio Announcements, Notice Boards	Capture citizen priorities for inclusion in budget. Notices to be sent 7 days before activity
Dissemination of Draft Budget	WDCs, Community Leaders, CSOs, Media	Annually	April (with notices sent 7 days prior)	Director Planning, Council Secretary	Physical Meetings, Digital Platforms (website, social media)	Ensure transparency and inclusivity before budget approval
Feedback Meetings on Approved Budget	Citizens, WDCs, Traditional Leaders	Annually (after budget approval)	May (with notices sent 7 days prior)	Council Secretary, WDCs	Public Meetings, Community Radio, Notice Boards	Provide feedback on what projects were included/excluded

Budget

The Ndola City Council has made a budgetary provision to support the Citizen Engagement Strategy. The budget allocation for this exercise has been pegged at K74,310.00 (**Seventy-Four Thousand, Three Hundred and Ten Kwacha Only**).

The allocation will fund the procurement of meals, transport refunds to participants, media sensitization, fuel and stationary.

There will be consideration for the inclusion of budget lines to support the CES.

Budget Line / Activity	Description	Estimated Cost (ZMW)	Frequency	Responsibility	Comments
1. Community Consultation Meetings	refreshments, stationery, transport refunds for WDC representatives and other participants. Conducted in 2 sessions of maximum attendance.	24,000	Bi-annual	PRO, ZANIS, all Directors	Key activity for gathering citizen input during budget formulation and other consultations and engagements; 7 days' notice to communities via radio, notice boards, and local announcements.
2. Capacity Building	Training for WDCs, CWACs, CSOs on CE processes, budgeting, monitoring. Led by technical staff in the institution.	6,000	Bi-annually	(SEPS, PRO, A/DCP, DCP,	Builds skills for meaningful participation and accountability while ensuring neutrality and effective facilitation.
3. Communication Materials	Printing reports and minutes	3,800	Annually	SEPs, DPO A/DCP, PRO,	Improves accessibility and transparency; ensures information is shared to all wards and stakeholders
4. Digital Engagement Platforms	Social media management, website updates, SMS surveys, online meeting support (data bundles, ICT tools).	800	Continuous	IT, PRO & SEPS, DPO, A/DCP	Extends participation to tech-savvy and remote citizens; focus on SMS and low-bandwidth tools.
5. Community Radio Programs	Airtime costs for council radio shows on budget, service delivery, and citizen feedback.	3500	annual	SEP, DPO, ADCP, DCP PRO.	Ensures information dissemination to rural and hard-to-reach areas of the district to promote transparency and accountability.
6. Grievance Redress Mechanism (GRM)	Suggestion boxes, hotline setup, grievance logbooks, staff training on handling complaints.	nil	Continuous	TC Secretary, PRO	Raises awareness of complaint channels and ensures usage; integral to trust and feedback loops.

7. Monitoring & Evaluation (M&E)	Field visits, surveys, data collection tools, analysis, and report writing on CE effectiveness.	3,000	annual	TC, Civic leaders, technical staff, WDCs	Provides evidence on outcomes and informs future CE planning; accounts for transport to locations.
8. Feedback & Reporting Meetings	Town Hall meetings, feedback sessions with WDCs on approved budget and implementation progress.	24,000	Bi-annually	SEP, PRO, DPO, A/DCP, DCP, TC & all directors	Promotes trust and transparency by reporting back to citizens; conducted in 2 sessions to maximize participation.
9. Administrative & Logistical Support	Transport refund s to outsiders participants .	12,000	Continuous	Admin Officer	Ensures smooth implementation of CE activities; covers rural travel
Total Estimated Budget		ZMW 74,310.00			

Monitoring, Evaluation and Reporting

Monitoring, evaluation, and reporting (MER) Framework Findings from MER and GRM will feed into annual reviews, ensuring that lessons learned directly inform adjustments in subsequent Citizen Engagement Plans. This creates a continuous learning loop for stronger inclusivity, accountability, and transparency.					
The table below provides for a tool to be used to monitor the Citizen Engagement Strategy					
Objective	Indicators	Means of Verification	Frequency	Responsible Officer / Institution	Reporting / Communication Channel
Improved accessibility and inclusivity	No. of public meetings, attendance by gender/age/PWDs, %age of wards conducting consultations	Meeting minutes, attendance registers, WDC reports	Bi-annually	PRO, SEPS, DPO, A/DCP, DCP, WDCs,	Notice boards, council website, community forums
Strengthen transparency and accountability	% representation of vulnerable groups; targeted outreach activities	Participation lists, workshop reports, CSO reports	Bi-annually	DCP, DPO, SEPS, CSOs, CDO	Annual CES report, radio programs
Enhance responsiveness and feedback mechanisms	% citizen proposals incorporated into final budget; # feedback meetings conducted	Budget documents, council resolutions, feedback reports	Annually	DCP, DF, TC	Public meetings, council website, local media

Conclusion

The development of the Ndola Citizen Engagement Strategy aims at promoting effective stakeholders' engagement in critical decision-making process and outcomes that will have an impact on their welfare and community at large. The plan emphasized stakeholder participation through various platforms and use of legally established structures for effective representation. This instrument further underscores the council's commitment to strengthen accountability and transparency in management of public resource for good governance in improved service delivery.

Annexes

Proposed template to be used as attendance register.

	Name	Designation	Gender		Age (Years)			Person With Disability PWD	Mobile Number	Signature
			M	F	Below 35	Between 35-59	Over 60			
1										
2										

3										
4										
5										
6										
7										
8										
9										
10										
Totals	Number attended		M	F						